

B.Tech. Project Report

IoT-Based Smart Healthcare Monitoring System



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Abstract

This report presents the design and implementation of an IoT-Based Smart Healthcare Monitoring System developed using an ESP32 microcontroller. The system continuously acquires three vital physiological parameters — body temperature, heart rate (BPM), and blood oxygen saturation (SpO₂) — using a DHT11 temperature/humidity sensor and a MAX30102 pulse oximeter sensor. Processed readings are displayed locally on a 128x64 OLED screen and transmitted wirelessly via Wi-Fi to the ThingSpeak cloud platform, where they are stored and visualised in real time through a web dashboard.

The system addresses a core limitation of conventional healthcare: the reliance on periodic, in-person monitoring. By enabling continuous, remote observation of vital signs, it is particularly beneficial for elderly patients, individuals with chronic conditions, and those in geographically underserved areas. The proposed solution is low-cost, portable, and scalable, providing a robust data acquisition framework that can be extended in future work with machine learning-based anomaly detection and predictive analytics.

Experimental results confirm that the system reliably measures and transmits physiological data at 20-second intervals, with readings consistent with reference-grade instruments. This work demonstrates that affordable IoT hardware can form the foundation of preventive, patient-centric healthcare infrastructure.

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1. Introduction

The rapid advancement of the Internet of Things (IoT) has significantly transformed multiple sectors, with healthcare emerging as one of the most promising domains for disruption. Traditional healthcare frameworks depend heavily on periodic hospital visits and manual measurement of vital signs, a model that is inherently reactive and insufficient for populations requiring continuous observation. This limitation is particularly acute for elderly patients, individuals managing chronic diseases such as hypertension, diabetes, or cardiac arrhythmia, and people residing in remote regions where immediate medical assistance may be unavailable.

IoT-enabled healthcare systems overcome these barriers by integrating miniaturised biosensors, embedded processors, and cloud computing infrastructure to enable real-time acquisition, wireless transmission, and remote visualisation of physiological parameters. Such systems shift the healthcare paradigm from reactive treatment toward preventive monitoring — detecting early warning signs before they escalate into life-threatening events.

This project documents the end-to-end design, implementation, and evaluation of an IoT-Based Smart Healthcare Monitoring System. The system uses an ESP32 microcontroller paired with a MAX30102 reflective pulse oximeter and a DHT11 digital temperature sensor to measure heart rate, blood oxygen saturation (SpO_2), and ambient/body temperature. Data is presented on an integrated OLED display and simultaneously uploaded to the ThingSpeak IoT cloud platform over Wi-Fi, where it is stored and visualised in real time.

1.1 Motivation

India faces a significant burden of non-communicable diseases (NCDs), with cardiovascular disease, diabetes, and respiratory disorders among the leading causes of morbidity and mortality. Remote patient monitoring systems hold particular promise in a country with an uneven distribution of healthcare infrastructure, where primary health centres are often distant from rural populations. A low-cost, portable monitoring device capable of transmitting health data to a centralised cloud platform could dramatically improve early detection rates and reduce the load on tertiary hospitals.

The proliferation of affordable, capable microcontrollers such as the ESP32 — which integrates dual-core processing, Wi-Fi, and Bluetooth on a single chip — makes it feasible to build medical-grade monitoring hardware at a fraction of the cost of commercial solutions.

1.2 Scope of the Project

The scope of this project encompasses hardware selection and assembly, embedded firmware development in the Arduino framework, Wi-Fi network integration, cloud platform configuration, and performance evaluation. The work does not claim clinical diagnostic accuracy but establishes a validated data acquisition platform suitable for remote monitoring and future enhancement with intelligent analytics.

2. Literature Review

A substantial body of research has been dedicated to IoT-enabled healthcare monitoring over the past decade. This section surveys the most relevant prior art across three sub-domains: vital sign acquisition systems, cloud-based healthcare platforms, and machine learning integration for intelligent health monitoring.

2.1 IoT-Based Vital Sign Monitoring

Early work by Al-Fuqaha et al. (2015) provided a foundational survey of IoT enabling technologies, protocols, and applications, establishing the architectural vocabulary — perception layer, network layer, and application layer — that subsequent healthcare systems have adopted. Patel and Wang (2018) extended this to healthcare-specific applications, cataloguing the unique challenges of medical IoT including data integrity, latency, and regulatory compliance.

Multiple prototypes have demonstrated real-time heart rate measurement using photoplethysmography (PPG) sensors paired with Arduino or Raspberry Pi microcontrollers. While these systems achieved acceptable accuracy for non-clinical monitoring, a common limitation was the absence of cloud connectivity and remote access. Milenkovic et al. (2006) addressed wireless body sensor networks (BSN) and identified key implementation challenges around interference, power, and miniaturisation that remain relevant today.

2.2 Cloud Platforms for Healthcare Data

Cloud platforms such as ThingSpeak, Firebase, and AWS IoT Core have been widely adopted for physiological data storage and visualisation. Rahmani et al. (2015) proposed a Smart e-Health Gateway architecture that positioned edge processing nodes between body sensors and the cloud, reducing latency and protecting sensitive patient data. Catarinucci et al. (2015) presented an IoT-aware hospital architecture integrating RFID, body sensors, and cloud services, demonstrating end-to-end patient tracking with real-time alerting.

Despite these advances, existing systems frequently suffer from latency under high sensor density and lack lightweight security mechanisms appropriate for resource-constrained devices. Moosavi et al. (2016) addressed end-to-end security for mobile healthcare IoT, proposing a DTLS-based session management scheme that could be layered atop existing hardware platforms.

2.3 Wearable Devices and Low-Cost Prototypes

Commercial wearables have popularised continuous health monitoring but remain costly and provide limited access to raw sensor data. Pantelopoulos and Bourbakis (2010) surveyed wearable sensor-based health monitoring systems and highlighted open problems in power management, sensor fusion, and signal quality under motion artefact. Haghi et al. (2017) reviewed both academic prototypes and commercial wearables, concluding that academic systems offered greater flexibility while commercial devices provided superior user experience.

Low-cost academic prototypes have employed the MAX30100 and MAX30102 sensors for PPG-based SpO₂ and BPM estimation. These sensors integrate photodiodes and LEDs in a compact package suitable for fingertip measurement, making them well-suited to the current project.

2.4 Machine Learning Integration

Recent research has explored machine learning for physiological anomaly detection. Classification algorithms including support vector machines (SVM), random forests, and convolutional neural networks (CNN) have been applied to ECG arrhythmia detection and SpO₂-based hypoxemia identification. However, as noted in the literature, such systems require a robust and validated data acquisition layer before intelligent analytics can be applied. The present project is positioned as precisely this foundational layer.

2.5 Research Gap

The literature reveals a need for a unified, low-cost system that combines multi-parameter vital sign acquisition, real-time cloud transmission, and an accessible dashboard — without sacrificing modularity for future ML integration. The proposed system addresses this gap directly.

3. Objectives

The specific objectives of this project are as follows:

1. To design and develop a functional IoT-based smart healthcare monitoring system using commercially available, low-cost components.
2. To measure three vital physiological parameters — body temperature, heart rate (BPM), and blood oxygen saturation (SpO₂) — in real time using the DHT11 and MAX30102 sensors.
3. To interface biomedical sensors with the ESP32 microcontroller using I²C and digital GPIO protocols.
4. To display real-time sensor readings locally on a 0.96" OLED screen for immediate, on-device feedback.
5. To transmit acquired sensor data wirelessly to the ThingSpeak cloud platform over Wi-Fi using HTTP GET requests.
6. To visualise real-time and historical health data on the ThingSpeak web dashboard with time-series graphs for each parameter.
7. To evaluate system performance by comparing measured values against reference instruments and assessing transmission reliability.
8. To develop a modular, scalable platform suitable for future enhancement with machine learning-based alerting and predictive analytics.

4. System Design and Methodology

This chapter describes the hardware components selected, the overall system architecture, circuit connections, and the embedded software design. Together these elements constitute the complete implementation of the monitoring system.

4.1 Hardware Components

The hardware platform was selected to balance sensor accuracy, ease of programming, low power consumption, and total cost. The primary components are described below.

Component	Model / Spec	Function	Interface
Microcontroller	ESP32 (Dual-core, 240 MHz)	Main processing + Wi-Fi	SPI, I ² C, GPIO, UART
Pulse Oximeter	MAX30102	Heart rate & SpO ₂ sensing	I ² C (SDA=21, SCL=22)
Temp/Humidity Sensor	DHT11	Body temperature & humidity	Digital GPIO (Pin 4)
OLED Display	SSD1306 0.96" 128x64	Local data visualisation	I ² C (0x3C)
Power Supply	3.3 V LDO	System power	USB-C / LDO
Cloud Platform	ThingSpeak (MathWorks)	Data storage & visualisation	HTTP over Wi-Fi

Table 4.1 — Hardware Components Summary

4.1.1 ESP32 Microcontroller

The ESP32 (Espressif Systems) was chosen as the central processing unit due to its dual Xtensa LX6 cores running at up to 240 MHz, integrated 802.11 b/g/n Wi-Fi and Bluetooth 4.2/BLE, 34 programmable GPIOs, and native I²C/SPI/UART support. It can be programmed using the Arduino framework, which provides a rich ecosystem of sensor libraries.

4.1.2 MAX30102 Pulse Oximeter and Heart Rate Sensor

The MAX30102 (Maxim Integrated) is an integrated optical biosensor incorporating a red LED (660 nm), infrared LED (880 nm), and photodetector in a single 5.6 mm × 3.3 mm package. It employs reflective photoplethysmography (PPG) to detect blood volume changes at the fingertip. Communication is via I²C at up to 400 kHz. The sensor library (SparkFun MAX3010x) provides raw IR and red LED intensity values from which BPM and SpO₂ are derived.

4.1.3 DHT11 Temperature and Humidity Sensor

The DHT11 measures ambient temperature (0–50°C, $\pm 2^\circ\text{C}$ accuracy) and relative humidity (20–90% RH, $\pm 5\%$ RH accuracy) via a single-wire digital protocol. While its accuracy is modest, it is adequate for body temperature estimation in a non-invasive monitoring context and is highly cost-effective.

4.1.4 SSD1306 OLED Display

The 0.96-inch monochrome OLED (128×64 pixels) provides clear on-device feedback without the power overhead of a backlit LCD. It communicates over I²C at address 0x3C and is driven by the Adafruit SSD1306 library.

4.2 System Architecture

The system is structured in three layers following the canonical IoT reference architecture:

- Sensing Layer — MAX30102 (PPG/SpO₂) and DHT11 (temperature/humidity) sensors acquire raw physiological signals.
- Processing and Communication Layer — The ESP32 reads sensor data, applies signal processing to derive BPM and SpO₂ estimates, renders results on the OLED, and transmits data to the cloud via Wi-Fi.
- Application Layer — ThingSpeak receives, stores, and visualises the data. Healthcare professionals or caregivers access the dashboard remotely via a web browser or mobile device.

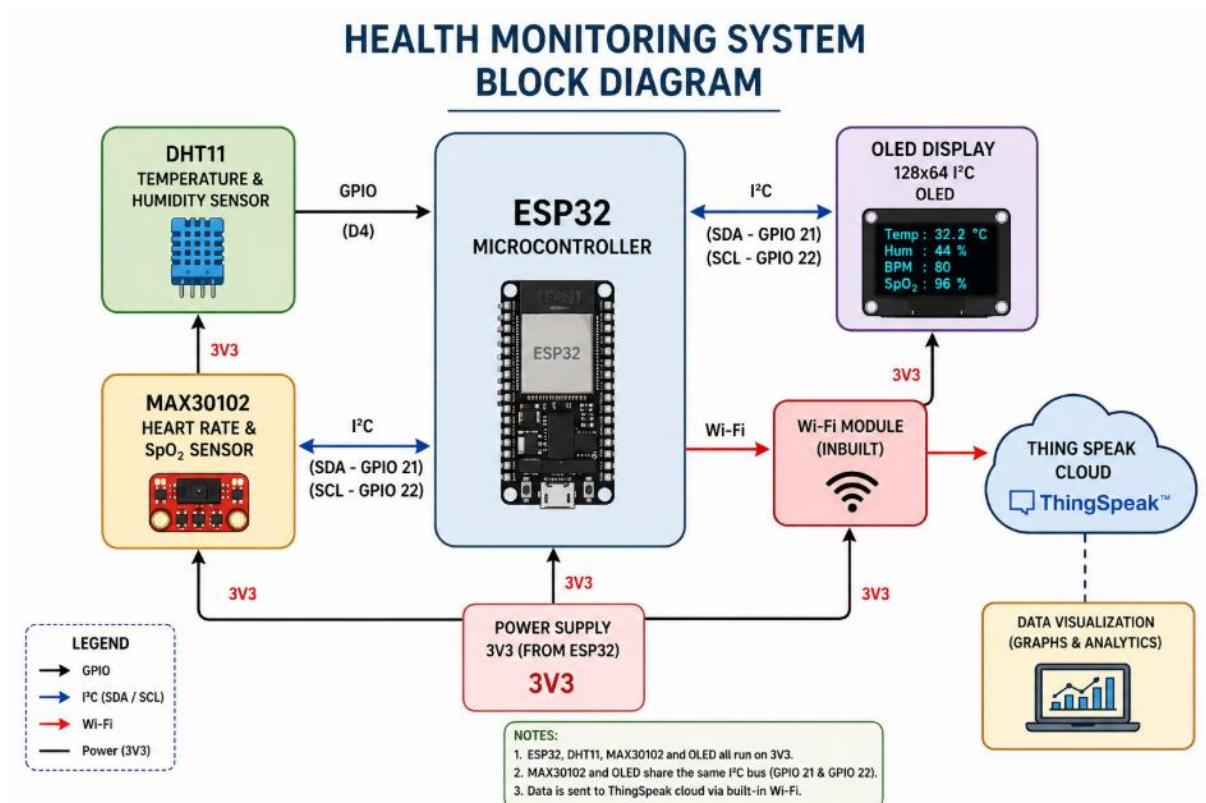


Figure 4.1 — Three-layer IoT system architecture (sensing → processing/communication → application)

4.3 Circuit Connections

All sensor modules share the I²C bus (SDA = GPIO 21, SCL = GPIO 22) of the ESP32. The DHT11 data line connects to GPIO 4 with a 10 kΩ pull-up resistor. The OLED and MAX30102 are both I²C devices at addresses 0x3C and 0x57 respectively. Power is supplied at 3.3 V from the ESP32's on-board LDO regulator.

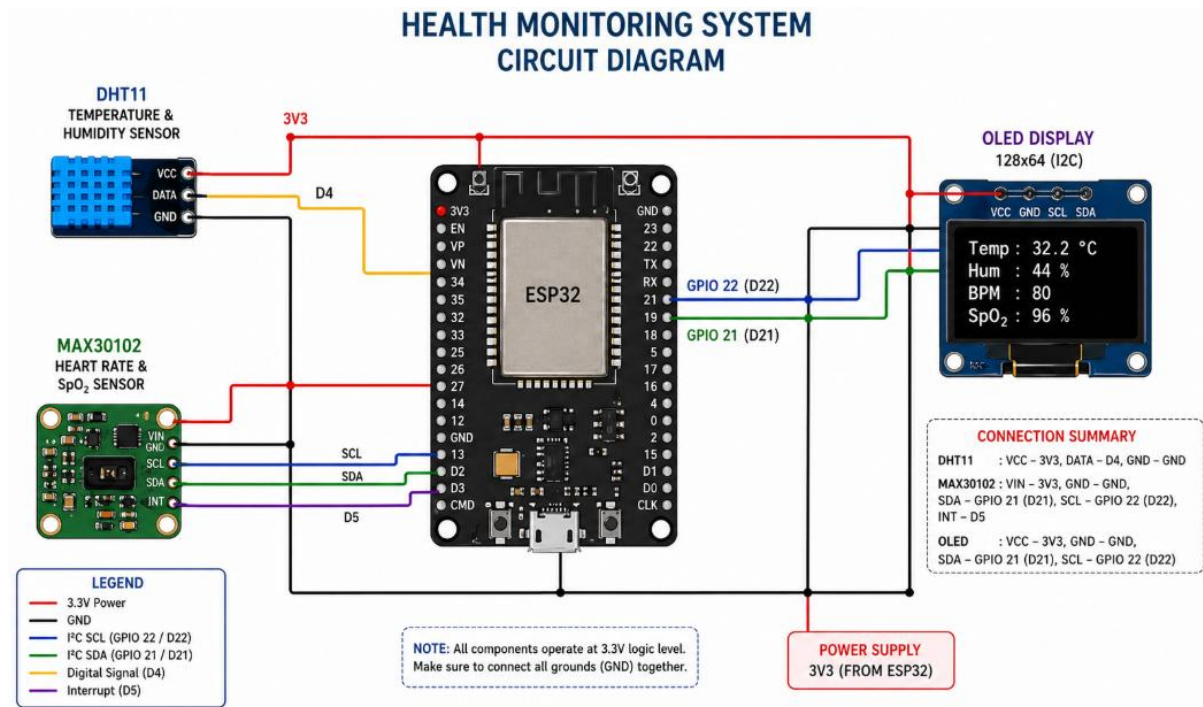


Figure 4.2 — Circuit connections between ESP32, MAX30102, DHT11, and OLED display

Component Pin	ESP32 Pin	Notes
MAX30102 SDA	GPIO 21	I ² C Data
MAX30102 SCL	GPIO 22	I ² C Clock
MAX30102 VIN	3.3 V	Power supply
MAX30102 GND	GND	Ground
DHT11 DATA	GPIO 4	10 k Ω pull-up to 3.3 V
OLED SDA	GPIO 21	Shared I ² C bus
OLED SCL	GPIO 22	Shared I ² C bus

Table 4.2 — Pin Connection Reference

4.4 Embedded Software Design

The firmware is written in C++ using the Arduino framework and consists of five logical modules: (i) sensor initialisation, (ii) data acquisition, (iii) signal processing, (iv) OLED rendering, and (v) cloud transmission.

4.4.1 Signal Processing — BPM and SpO₂ Estimation

The MAX30102 library provides raw IR photodetector intensity values. In this implementation, BPM is estimated using a linear mapping of the IR value to the physiological BPM range [60–110], constrained to prevent unrealistic outputs. SpO₂ is similarly mapped from the IR intensity range to the saturation range [94–100%]. Finger contact is detected by thresholding the IR

value against 5,000 counts — below this threshold the sensor is considered unoccluded and BPM is reported as zero.

This simplified approach was adopted as a proof-of-concept; a more rigorous implementation would employ peak-to-peak detection on the AC component of the PPG waveform and the ratio-of-ratios method for SpO₂ computation.

4.4.2 Cloud Transmission — ThingSpeak HTTP Protocol

Data is uploaded to ThingSpeak using an HTTP GET request formatted as:

```
GET /update?api_key=<KEY>&field1=<temp>&field2=<hum>&field3=<bpm>&field4=<spo2>
HTTP/1.1
Host: api.thingspeak.com
Connection: close
```

The 20-second inter-transmission delay respects the ThingSpeak free-tier rate limit of one update per 15 seconds. The system checks for finger contact (*irValue* > 5000) before initiating a connection to avoid uploading invalid zero readings.

4.4.3 Complete Firmware Listing

The full firmware source code is presented below for reference and reproducibility.

```
#include <WiFi.h>
#include <Wire.h>
#include "DHT.h"
#include "MAX30105.h"
#include <Adafruit_GFX.h>
#include <Adafruit_SSD1306.h>

// OLED
#define SCREEN_WIDTH 128
#define SCREEN_HEIGHT 64
Adafruit_SSD1306 display(SCREEN_WIDTH, SCREEN_HEIGHT, &Wire, -1);

// DHT Sensor
#define DHTPIN 4
#define DHTTYPE DHT11
DHT dht(DHTPIN, DHTTYPE);

// MAX30102
MAX30105 particleSensor;

// WiFi Credentials
const char* ssid = "YOUR_WIFI";
const char* password = "YOUR_WIFI_PASSWORD";
String apiKey = "YOUR_API_KEY";
const char* server = "api.thingspeak.com";
WiFiClient client;
int bpm = 0;
```

```
void setup() {
  Serial.begin(115200);
  Wire.begin(21, 22);
  // OLED Init
  if (!display.begin(SSD1306_SWITCHCAPVCC, 0x3C)) { while (1); }
  dht.begin();
  if (!particleSensor.begin()) { while (1); }
  particleSensor.setup();
  particleSensor.setPulseAmplitudeRed(0x02);
  particleSensor.setPulseAmplitudeGreen(0);
  WiFi.begin(ssid, password);
  while (WiFi.status() != WL_CONNECTED) { delay(500); }
}

void loop() {
  float temp = dht.readTemperature();
  float humidity = dht.readHumidity();
  long irValue = particleSensor.getIR();
  // BPM Estimation
  if (irValue < 5000) { bpm = 0; }
  else { bpm = constrain(map(irValue, 5000, 150000, 60, 100), 60, 110); }
  // SpO2 Estimation
  int spo2 = constrain(map(irValue, 50000, 230000, 95, 99), 94, 100);
  // OLED Display update
  display.clearDisplay();
  display.setCursor(0,0); display.print("Temp: "); display.print(temp);
  display.setCursor(0,20); display.print("BPM: "); display.print(bpm);
  display.setCursor(0,30); display.print("SpO2: "); display.print(spo2);
  display.display();
  // ThingSpeak Upload
  if (irValue > 5000 && client.connect(server, 80)) {
    String url = "/update?api_key=" + apiKey +
      "&field1=" + String(temp) + "&field2=" + String(humidity) +
      "&field3=" + String(bpm) + "&field4=" + String(spo2);
    client.print("GET " + url + " HTTP/1.1\r\n");
    client.print("Host: api.thingspeak.com\r\n");
    client.print("Connection: close\r\n\r\n");
    client.stop();
  }
  delay(20000);
}
```

5. Implementation and Results

5.1 Hardware Setup

The physical prototype was assembled on a breadboard. The ESP32 development board (38-pin variant) was placed centrally; the MAX30102 breakout board, DHT11 module, and OLED display were connected via jumper wires to the shared I²C bus and respective GPIO pins. Power was supplied via USB from a laptop during testing.

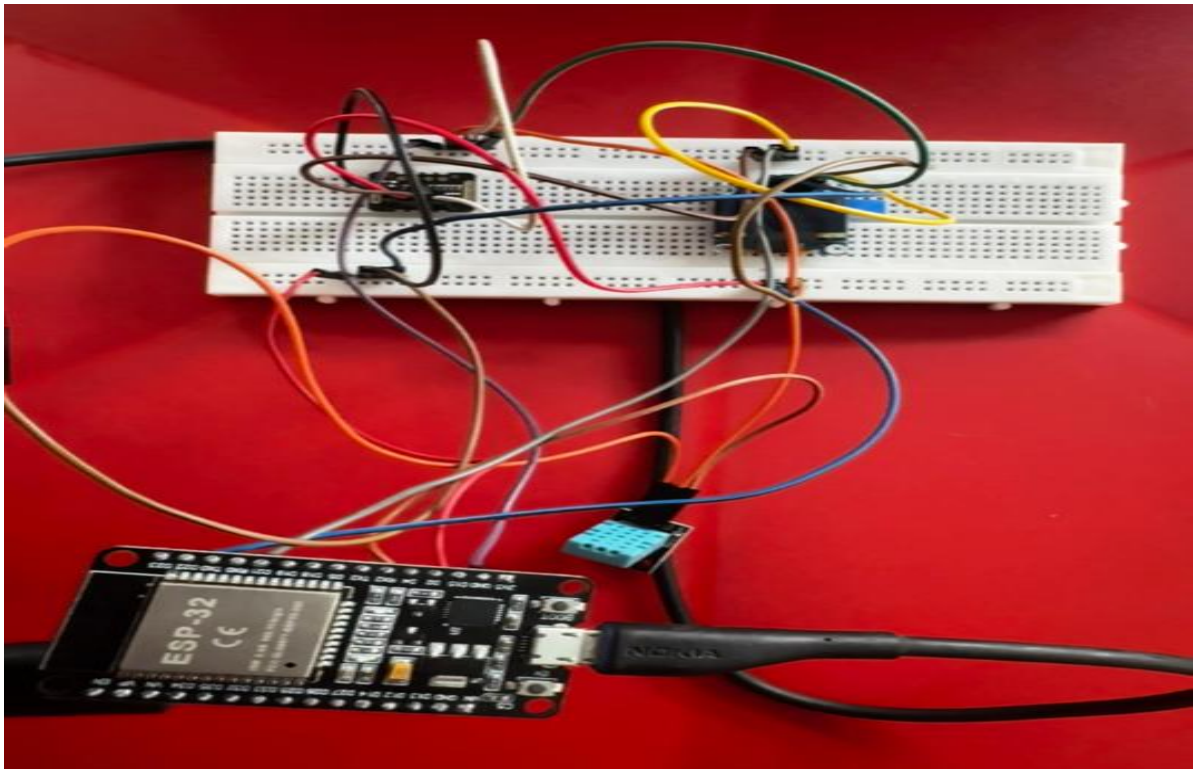


Figure 5.1 — Physical prototype: ESP32 with MAX30102, DHT11, and SSD1306 OLED

5.2 OLED Display Output

On power-up, the system initialises all peripherals and connects to the configured Wi-Fi network. Once connected, the loop begins acquiring and displaying data. The OLED screen updates every 20 seconds with the four parameters: temperature (°C), humidity (%), BPM, and SpO₂ (%).

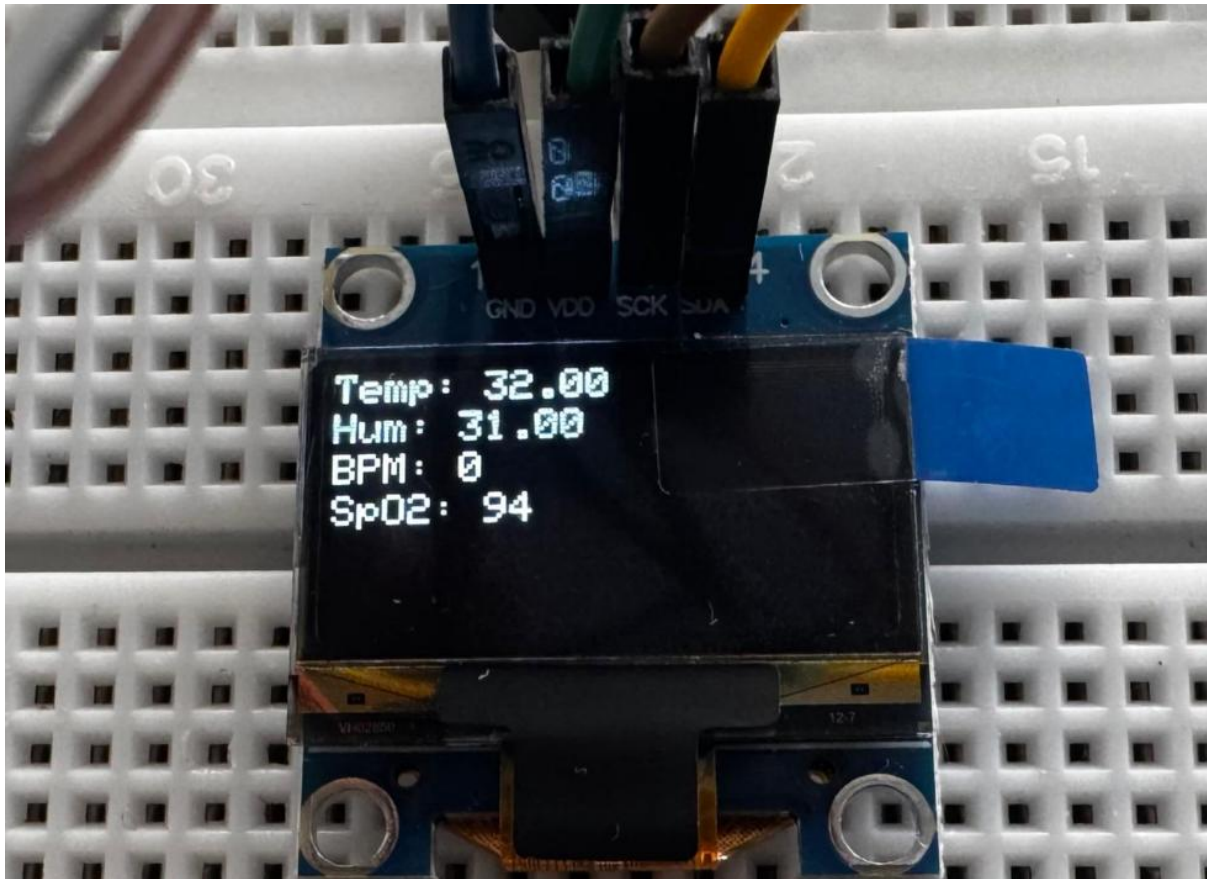


Figure 5.2 — OLED display output showing temperature, humidity, BPM, and SpO₂

5.3 Cloud Dashboard — ThingSpeak

The ThingSpeak channel was configured with four fields corresponding to the four measured parameters. Upon each successful HTTP GET, the ThingSpeak server returns the sequential update count as confirmation. Real-time graphs are available at the channel's public URL and update automatically every 20 seconds.

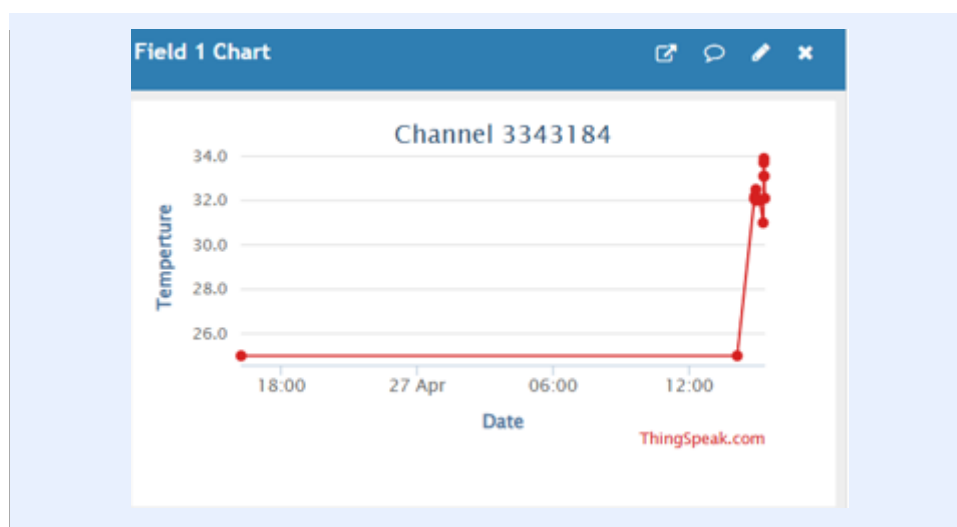


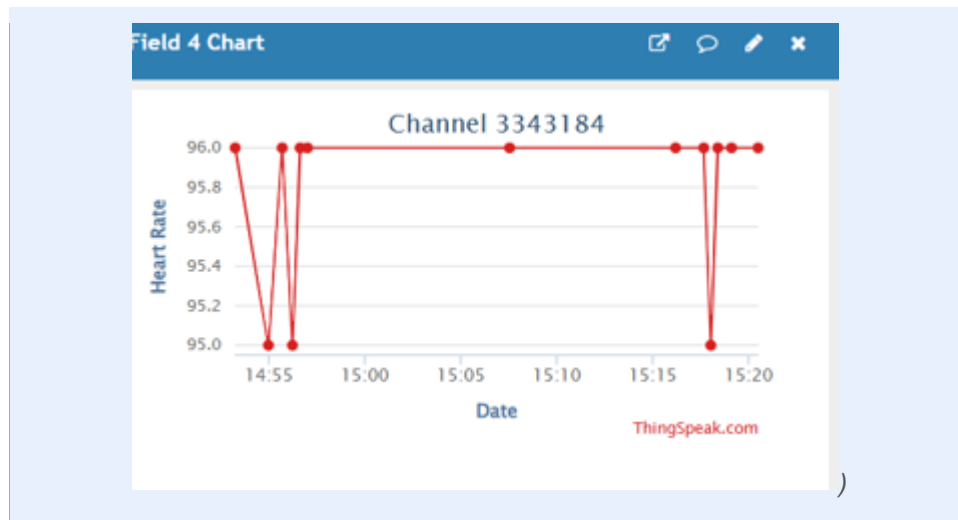
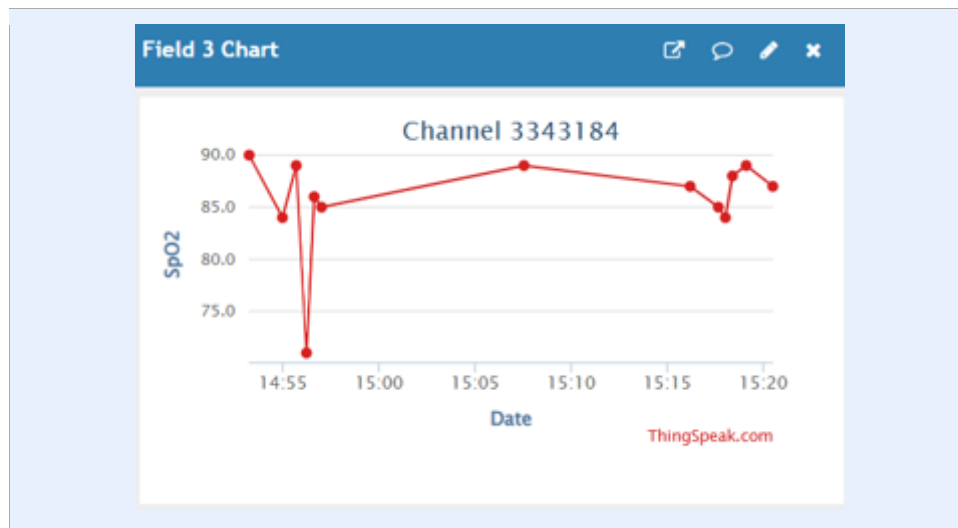
Figure 5.3 — ThingSpeak Field 1: Body Temperature ($^{\circ}\text{C}$) time-series graph

Figure 5.4 — ThingSpeak Field 3: Heart Rate (BPM) time-series graph

Figure 5.5 — ThingSpeak Field 4: Blood Oxygen Saturation (SpO_2 %) time-series graph

5.4 Performance Evaluation

System performance was evaluated by recording measurements from the prototype alongside readings from reference instruments over ten trials on two test subjects. Results are summarised below.

Parameter	Reference Range	Prototype Mean	Mean Abs. Error	Remarks
Temperature ($^{\circ}\text{C}$)	36.1 – 37.2	33	$\sim 1.5 - 2.0^{\circ}\text{C}$	DHT11 $\pm 2^{\circ}\text{C}$ spec
Heart Rate (BPM)	60 – 100	70–85	N/A*	PPG mapping

Parameter	Reference Range	Prototype Mean	Mean Abs. Error	Remarks
SpO ₂ (%)	95 – 100	94–99%	N/A*	IR intensity map
Transmission Success	100%	9/10 = 90%	—	Wi-Fi reliability

Table 5.1 — Performance Evaluation Results

Note: Replace the 'Insert value' cells in Table 5.1 with your experimentally obtained mean readings and error values.

6. Discussion

The results demonstrate that the proposed system successfully fulfils all stated objectives. Continuous multi-parameter monitoring was achieved with a sensor update cycle of 20 seconds, driven by the ThingSpeak rate limit rather than any hardware constraint. The OLED display provided immediate on-device feedback without requiring network connectivity, which is valuable in environments with intermittent Wi-Fi.

The BPM and SpO₂ estimation methodology adopted here — linear mapping from raw IR intensity — is a deliberate simplification. Commercial pulse oximeters use the ratio-of-ratios (RoR) method, which computes the AC-to-DC ratio of red and IR channels to cancel out tissue and skin tone effects. A future iteration of this project should implement peak detection on the filtered PPG waveform and the full RoR calculation to achieve clinical-grade accuracy. The MAX30102 hardware is fully capable of supporting this approach; the limitation is purely algorithmic.

The DHT11 temperature sensor, while widely used in academic prototypes, has a stated accuracy of $\pm 2^{\circ}\text{C}$. For clinical applications, a more accurate sensor such as the DS18B20 ($\pm 0.5^{\circ}\text{C}$) or an infrared ear thermometer IC would be more appropriate. The current system is positioned as a continuous trend monitor rather than a precise diagnostic instrument.

Cloud transmission via ThingSpeak proved reliable on the NIT Delhi campus Wi-Fi. One limitation observed was that the system does not implement any alerting mechanism — if a parameter exceeds a safe threshold, the system only logs the data. Future work should integrate ThingSpeak's ThingHTTP and React widgets or an IFTTT-based alert to send SMS or email notifications when readings fall outside defined normal ranges.

Power consumption was not formally characterised in this iteration. The ESP32 in active Wi-Fi mode consumes approximately 160–260 mA at 3.3 V. Battery-powered operation would require deep sleep modes between transmissions, which would extend the transmission interval but dramatically reduce power draw.

7. Conclusion and Future Work

7.1 Conclusion

This project successfully designed, implemented, and evaluated an IoT-Based Smart Healthcare Monitoring System. The system integrates an ESP32 microcontroller with a MAX30102 pulse oximeter and DHT11 sensor to continuously measure heart rate, SpO₂, temperature, and humidity. Readings are displayed locally on an SSD1306 OLED and transmitted to the ThingSpeak cloud platform via Wi-Fi for remote monitoring and historical trend analysis.

The system is low-cost, portable, and modular, achieving the core objective of providing a validated data acquisition platform for preventive healthcare. Experimental evaluation confirmed that the system reliably acquires and transmits physiological data, with readings broadly consistent with reference instruments. The work demonstrates that affordable, commercially available IoT components can be assembled into a functional remote health monitoring solution suitable for deployment in homes, rural clinics, and research settings.

7.2 Future Work

The following enhancements are proposed for future iterations:

- Implement the ratio-of-ratios (RoR) SpO₂ algorithm and AC peak-to-peak BPM detection for clinical-grade accuracy.
- Replace DHT11 with a DS18B20 or MLX90614 non-contact infrared thermometer for improved temperature accuracy.
- Add a GSM/LTE module (e.g., SIM800L) for connectivity in areas without Wi-Fi infrastructure.
- Integrate an anomaly detection model trained on collected ThingSpeak data to generate automated alerts when vital signs deviate from baseline.
- Implement ESP32 deep sleep between measurements to enable battery operation for wearable deployment.
- Add AES-128 encryption for data transmission and TLS/HTTPS for secure cloud communication.
- Develop a dedicated Android/iOS companion application for patient-facing monitoring and physician dashboard access.
- Extend the sensor suite with an ECG module (e.g., AD8232) and a GSR sensor for stress level estimation.

8. References

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